Guitar Exercises - Section XII, Level 87

Reggae, Ska, Soul, Disco, and Motown Groove Principles

Offbeats • Clipped Chords • Repeated Figures • Octave/Bass Interaction • Section Texture

Level 87 of the fixed 105-level core curriculum. HARD STOP after Level 105.

Level 86 focused on funk and R&B.; Level 87 broadens the groove vocabulary while keeping the same fundamental rule: style is created by attack placement, duration, muting, register, repetition, and interaction with the rhythm section - not by chord names alone.

Module	Exercise	Events
A	Offbeat placement and clipped skank control	128
B	Ska upstroke continuity and accent rotation	128
C	Soul backbeats and repeated rhythm figures	144
D	Motown-style chord/bass interlock	144
E	Disco octave interaction and upper-voicing pulse	128
F	Section-specific texture and density changes	128
G	Style contrast on identical progressions	160
H	Four eight-bar groove studies	192
I	Thirty-two-bar style-navigation capstone	256
J	Recovery and style-identity audit	64
	TOTAL	1472

Core rule: preserve pulse first, then style identity. If the groove becomes unclear, reduce to one chord and one bar.

Reference - Style Identity Variables

Style family	Primary placement	Duration	Register	Rhythm-section relationship
Reggae	offbeat eighths / selected &s	very clipped	middle-upper	leave downbeat and bass space
Ska	continuous offbeat upstrokes	clipped	middle-upper	brighter attack, stronger motion
Soul	backbeats and repeated figures	medium/short	middle	support vocal pocket; answer after chord
Motown	repeated rhythmic figures	short/medium	middle	interlock with bass, avoid duplicating fills
Disco	steady eighth/sixteenth pulse	short but even	upper	lock with octave bass and kick pulse

These are foundational principles, not definitions of entire genres. The exercises teach transferable groove mechanics.

Module A - Reggae Offbeat Placement

Use C-F-G-C. Keep the downbeat physically present in the counting hand but mostly silent in the fretting/attack hand.

Cell	Count	Contact pattern	Goal
1	1 & 2 & 3 & 4 &	- P - P - P - P	basic offbeat skank
2	1 & 2 & 3 & 4 &	- P - P - x - P	one muted backbeat
3	1 & 2 & 3 & 4 &	- P - x - P - x	alternating chord/mute
4	1 e & a ...	--P- --P- --P- --P-	sixteenth-grid version
5	1 e & a ...	--P- --x- --P- --x-	skank + ghost alternation
6	1 e & a ...	---- --P- ---- --P-	extreme space

Every pitched chord must release before the following downbeat. Use three-string triads or partial barres rather than large grips.

Module A - Clipped Chord Duration Ladder

Pass	Attack	Release
1	& of every beat	hold to next downbeat
2	& of every beat	release halfway before next downbeat
3	& of every beat	release almost immediately
4	& of 2 and & of 4 only	very short stabs
5	& of 2 and & of 4	alternate pitched and muted stabs

The goal is not maximum shortness. The goal is repeatable note length. Record the same four bars three times; compare whether every stab ends at a similar point.

Module B - Ska Upstroke Continuity

The right hand moves continuously while the chord is contacted mainly on the upstroke/offbeat. The motion should not become a sequence of isolated pokes.

Cell	Grid	Accent
1	-P-P-P-P	all offbeats equal
2	-P-P-P-P	accent & of 2 and & of 4
3	-P-P-P-P	accent & of 1 and & of 3
4	-P-x-P-x	alternate pitched/muted
5	-x-P-x-P	reverse alternation
6	-P-P-x-P	single mute displacement
7	-P-x-P-P	late-section lift
8	-P-P-P-x	ending preparation

Use C major, F major, G major, and A minor triads on the top three strings. Keep the low strings silent.

Module C - Soul Backbeats and Repeated Figures

Figure	Count	Use
Backbeat shell	1 2 3 4	rests on 1/3, shell on 2/4
Delayed answer	1 & 2 & 3 & 4 &	shell on 2, answer on &3
Repeated two-beat cell	1 & 2 & | 3 & 4 &	same rhythm twice
Pickup figure	4 & | 1	two-note pickup into next chord
Call/response	bar 1 / bar 2	chord figure then melodic answer
Held support	1~~~ 2 3 4	long chord under vocal space

Apply to Cmaj7-Am7-Dm7-G7. The repeated figure should remain recognizable as chords change.

Module D - Motown-Style Chord/Bass Interlock

Practice the bass figure first, then place the guitar where it complements rather than duplicates it.

Bass behavior	Guitar response
Root on 1, fifth on 3	short shell on 2 and 4
Root-octave eighths	upper triad on selected offbeats
Walking quarters	one repeated chord figure per half-bar
Bass fill on beat 4	guitar rests on beat 4
Syncopated pickup into next root	guitar sustains through pickup
Pedal bass	guitar changes inversion above pedal

Use I-vi-IV-V and I-IV-V-I progressions. Repeat one two-beat guitar rhythm for at least four bars before varying it.

Module D - Repeated Rhythm-Figure Discipline

Cell	Pattern	Variation rule
A	P--- --P-	repeat 4 bars before changing
B	--P- P---	same rhythm, new chord
C	P-P- --x-	one ghost added only after 4 bars
D	-P-- -P--	offbeat shell repeated through progression
E	P--- P-x-	keep figure, change register at section boundary
F	P~-- --P-	hold first hit, clip second

The purpose is to resist overplaying. A repeated guitar figure can become part of the arrangement's identity.

Module E - Disco Octave/Bass Interaction

Disco-style guitar often occupies a bright register while the bass carries strong octave motion. The guitar should reinforce the pulse without covering the bass line.

Study	Bass	Guitar
1	root-octave eighths	upper triad on every &
2	root-octave-root-octave	short shell on 2 and 4
3	continuous octave pulse	steady 16th muted grid + selected stabs
4	bass fill beat 4	guitar rests beat 4
5	octave rise into chorus	guitar moves to higher inversion
6	octave descent into verse	guitar reduces density

Use Am7-D7-Gmaj7-Cmaj7. Keep every guitar contact equal in length before adding accents.

Module F - Section-Specific Texture

Section	Reggae/Ska option	Soul/Motown option	Disco option
Verse	2 offbeat stabs/bar	one repeated figure	sparse upper triads
Pre	4 offbeats/bar	rising register	increase muted 16ths
Chorus	full offbeat pattern	backbeat + answer	steady upper pulse
Bridge	half-time skank	held shells	reduce to 2/4 hits
Outro	decreasing density	repeat signature figure	sustain final upper chord

Rehearse one four-chord progression using all three texture columns. Harmony remains identical; arrangement changes.

Module G - Style Contrast on Identical Progressions

Style	Progression	Instruction
Reggae	C-F-G-C	offbeat triads; clipped; downbeats empty
Ska	C-F-G-C	continuous offbeat upstrokes; brighter accents
Soul	C-F-G-C	shells on 2/4; short answer fills
Motown	C-F-G-C	repeat one two-beat chord figure
Disco	C-F-G-C	steady upper-register pulse; even duration
Reggae	Am-F-C-G	sparse offbeats; bass carries roots
Soul	Am-F-C-G	longer backbeat shells
Disco	Am-F-C-G	high triads + muted sixteenth motion

Record each version at the same tempo. The style contrast should remain obvious even if all chord extensions are removed.

Module G - One-Bar Signature Tests

Prompt	One-bar task
Reggae identity	make 4/4 feel spacious using only two pitched chord attacks
Ska identity	continuous upstroke motion with four clipped offbeats
Soul identity	backbeat shell plus one short melodic answer
Motown identity	one repeated figure; no variation for four bars
Disco identity	upper triad pulse over imagined octave bass
Contrast test	switch style at barline without changing chord or tempo

If the style cannot be heard from one bar, simplify further. Add complexity only after the signature behavior is unmistakable.

Module H - Study 1 - Reggae/Ska contrast

| C | F | G | C | Am | F | G | G |

Bars 1-4 reggae: sparse clipped offbeats. Bars 5-8 ska: continuous offbeat upstrokes.

Pass	Requirement
1	clap/tap signature rhythm
2	muted strings
3	triads/shells
4	add bass-space decisions
5	add section texture
6	record with click only on 2 and 4

Module H - Study 2 - Soul/Motown contrast

| Cmaj7 | Am7 | Fmaj7 | G7 | Em7 | A7 | Dm7 | G7 |

Bars 1-4 soul: backbeat shells + answers. Bars 5-8 Motown: one repeated two-beat guitar figure.

Pass	Requirement
1	clap/tap signature rhythm
2	muted strings
3	triads/shells
4	add bass-space decisions
5	add section texture
6	record with click only on 2 and 4

Module H - Study 3 - Disco build

| Am7 | D7 | Gmaj7 | Cmaj7 | Am7 | D7 | Gmaj7 | E7 |

Upper triads; steady pulse; register rise in bars 5-8; bass fills get space.

Pass	Requirement
1	clap/tap signature rhythm
2	muted strings
3	triads/shells
4	add bass-space decisions
5	add section texture
6	record with click only on 2 and 4

Module H - Study 4 - Mixed arrangement

| C | Am | F | G | C | Am | Dm | G |

Reggae verse -> soul pre -> disco chorus texture over one progression.

Pass	Requirement
1	clap/tap signature rhythm
2	muted strings
3	triads/shells
4	add bass-space decisions
5	add section texture
6	record with click only on 2 and 4

Module I - Thirty-Two-Bar Style-Navigation Capstone

Bars	Harmony	Style	Primary behavior	Dynamic
1-4	C-F-G-C	reggae	2-4 clipped offbeats	mp
5-8	C-F-G-C	ska	continuous upstrokes	mf
9-12	Cmaj7-Am7-Fmaj7-G7	soul	backbeat shells + answers	mp
13-16	Cmaj7-Am7-Fmaj7-G7	Motown	repeated 2-beat figure	mf
17-20	Am7-D7-Gmaj7-Cmaj7	disco	upper pulse + octave-bass space	f
21-24	Am-F-C-G	reggae/soul hybrid	sparse offbeats + held shell	mp
25-28	C-Am-F-G	Motown/disco hybrid	repeated figure -> upper pulse	mf
29-32	Cmaj7-A7-Dm7-G7	release/outro	soul figure -> sustained tonic	f -> p

The master tempo never changes. Announce the next style on beat 4 of the previous section. Do not insert a neutral bar between styles.

Module I - Capstone Performance Ladder

Pass	Requirement
1	muted strings only; style changes must still be audible
2	add harmony with one voicing family
3	add register changes
4	add bass-space decisions
5	add section dynamics
6	record one uninterrupted 32-bar take

Hard transition test: randomly cue one style change one bar early or one bar late. Preserve bar count and move the style without changing the harmony.

Module J - Recovery and Style-Identity Audit

Failure	Immediate repair
Reggae stabs ring too long	reduce voicing; exaggerate release
Ska motion becomes stiff	air-strum all downstrokes; contact only upstrokes
Soul becomes too busy	remove all fills; retain backbeat shells
Motown figure keeps changing	commit to one 2-beat rhythm for 4 bars
Disco guitar covers bass	move higher and remove beat-4 attack
Style change alters tempo	one muted bar at same pulse, then restore harmony
Bass fill is covered	delete guitar contact at fill landmark
Form lost	one upper triad on beat 2 and 4 until next section

Style identity is judged from attack placement, length, repetition, register, and rhythm-section relationship - not from effects or chord extensions.

Level 87 Mastery and Fixed Roadmap

Category	0	1	2
Pulse	lost	recovers	stable
Offbeat accuracy	inconsistent	mostly	precise
Note length	uncontrolled	usable	repeatable
Repeated-figure discipline	constantly varies	mostly repeats	controlled
Bass-space discipline	collides	some space	intentional
Register/texture	flat	some contrast	clear
Style contrast	unclear	recognizable	immediate
Recovery	restart	simplifies	seamless

Pass: 14/16 or better on two separate days, with no zero in pulse, offbeat accuracy, bass-space discipline, or recovery.

Next: Level 88 develops rock, hard-rock, metal, and palm-muted groove control - eighth-note drive, gallops, pedal tones, power-chord displacement, accent architecture, and riff/section contrast.

Fixed roadmap: 85-90 Groove & Stylistic Rhythm; 91-94 Advanced Expression; 95-99 Repertoire Integration; 100-104 Composition; 105 Final Musicianship Capstone. HARD STOP after 105.